INC-0412: Payment processing delays (14 March 2024)

Severity: SEV-2. Incident commander: Daniel Okafor. Status: closed.

Summary

On 14 March 2024 card payments were slow to authorize and confirm. 1,840 payments were delayed by more than five minutes. No payment was lost or charged twice.

Timeline (UTC)

08:55 - CHG-2294 deployed: checkout-api now times out calls to fraud-scoring after 3 seconds and retries once.
09:05 - CHG-2291 deployed: the payments-db connection pool was reduced from 50 to 20 connections.
09:12 - First alert: checkout-api p95 latency above 4 seconds.
09:40 - ledger-worker consumer lag above 20 minutes.
10:05 - CHG-2291 reverted (pool back to 50). Latency and lag returned to normal. Incident resolved.

Root cause

The smaller connection pool (CHG-2291) could not serve peak checkout traffic. Requests waited for a database connection, and the new fraud-scoring timeout (CHG-2294) turned the slow ones into retries, which doubled the load on the pool.

Affected services

checkout-api, payments-db and ledger-worker. fraud-scoring itself stayed healthy.

Follow-up actions

1. Load-test pool changes before release (owner: Platform Data).
2. Alert on ledger-worker lag above 10 minutes (owner: Payments).